

Referencing primary & secondary data with APA

When you use someone else's data, words or ideas in a data-analysis project, you have to say where they came from. The APA system is the agreed way to do that — so your reader can trust your work and trace every source.

What this key knowledge covers

This summary distils everything you need for **KK07 — Referencing primary & secondary data with APA** in Data Analysis. Work through the explanations, then use the worked good-vs-weak answers to see exactly how marks are won and lost. Tick off the revision checklist at the end before a SAC or exam.

Study summary

References are receipts for ideas

Imagine you're audited and asked, “Where did this number come from?” If you kept the **receipt**, you can prove it instantly. A reference is that receipt: it proves the data isn't yours invented out of thin air, and it shows exactly where to buy the same “item” again.

The receipt analogy

A receipt records **who** you bought from, **when**, **what** the item was and **where** the shop is. An APA reference records the same four things about a source — Author, Date, Title, Source. Lose the receipt and you can't prove anything; lose the reference and it looks like you stole the idea.

Chain of custody (for the forensics crowd)

In digital forensics, every piece of evidence needs an unbroken record of where it came from and who handled it — or it's thrown out of court. Referencing is the **chain of custody for information**: an unbroken trail from your conclusion back to the original source, so anyone can verify it held up.

Hold onto the four words WHO · WHEN · WHAT · WHERE. Every APA reference is built from them, and you'll see them again in the 3D builder below.

Why we reference at all

“To make it look professional” is *not* a mark-earning answer. Referencing exists for four concrete reasons:

Data, writing and images are someone's intellectual property. Referencing gives legal and ethical credit to the creator.

Presenting others' work as your own is plagiarism — an academic integrity breach that can void an assessment.

A reader can follow the reference to the original source, check your data is real, current and not misrepresented.

Well-sourced findings are trustworthy. Referencing shows your conclusions rest on evidence, not opinion.

Primary vs secondary sources

The study design names **both**, so examiners love asking you to tell them apart. The test is simple: did the data come straight to you, first-hand, or had someone already collected and reported it?

Data **you** collect yourself, for your specific purpose, that didn't exist before you gathered it.

- A survey you run on student canteen choices
- An interview you conduct and record
- Temperature readings from your own sensor
- Observations you make and log

Data **someone else** already collected, published or analysed, that you re-use in your project.

- ABS census figures from a data repository
- A journal article reporting a study
- A news report, textbook or website
- A Kaggle / data.gov.au dataset

The anatomy of an APA reference

Every reference is four blocks snapped together: WHO wrote it, WHEN, WHAT it's called, and WHERE to find it. Spin the model, then tap a block to light up its part in the live reference below. Switch the source type to watch the same four blocks describe a website, a journal article, a dataset or an AI tool.

The two halves: in-text + reference list

APA always works as a **pair**. A short pointer sits in your writing; the full details live in a list at the end. Every in-text citation must have a matching entry in the reference list, and vice-versa.

A brief signpost *inside* your sentence — usually just author and year — so the reader knows that claim came from a source.

The *full* details at the end, under a **References** heading, alphabetical, with a hanging indent.

APA formats for the sources you'll actually use

You don't memorise these character-by-character, but you must know the **order** (Author → Date → Title → Source) and what gets italicised. Italics go on the title of a *standalone* work (book, journal, report, dataset, site) — never on an article/chapter title.

The VCAA explicitly points to APA's method for acknowledging AI. If a tool helped generate or summarise content, you reference it like any other source — and note in your method how you

used it.

APA citation builder

Pick a source type, type in the details, and watch a correctly-formatted APA reference assemble. Great for revision: cover the output, build it in your head, then check.

Citing inside your writing

Two flavours: **parenthetical** (everything in brackets at the end) and **narrative** (the author becomes part of your sentence). Note the small but examinable difference: use & inside brackets, but the word **and** in narrative text.

Reference list rules

- **Alphabetical order** by the first author's surname — not the order you used them.
- **Hanging indent** — the first line is flush left, every line after it is indented.
- **Italicise the standalone work** — book / journal / report / dataset / site title. Article and chapter titles are *not* italicised.
- **Sentence case** for article and book titles — capitalise only the first word, the first word after a colon, and proper nouns. Journal and newspaper *names* keep Title Case.
- **Ampersand &** between authors in the list (and in brackets); the word **and** in your sentences.
- **Heading “References”**, centred and bold, on its own.

Structure an answer: Point · Evidence · Link

Short-answer marks come from structured responses, not single words. P·E·L keeps you on track: state the **Point**, back it with an **Example/Evidence**, then **Link** it to the question's context.

Answer the actual command word directly in one clear sentence.

Give a concrete instance, format or rule that proves the point.

Connect it back to the scenario, data or consequence in the question.

Worked example. *“Explain why a student must reference a dataset downloaded from a repository.” (2 marks)*

Common traps & misconceptions

Exam trap

1 “It looks professional” as the purpose Vague and unmarked. Fix: name a real purpose — acknowledge intellectual property, avoid plagiarism, or let readers verify the source.

Exam trap

2 Calling a reporting source “primary” A textbook or news report about a study is secondary. Fix: primary = collected first-hand by you or the original researcher.

Exam trap

3 Reference list not alphabetical Listing sources in order of use loses the “correct conventions” mark. Fix: sort A-Z by first author surname.

Exam trap

4 Italicising the wrong thing Italics belong on the journal / book / dataset name, not the article title. Fix: italicise the *standalone work* only.

Exam trap

5 Mixing “&” and “and” & in brackets and the list; **and** in narrative sentences. Fix: match the form to the position.

Exam trap

6 A missing component Dropping the date or source breaks the reference. Fix: check all four — WHO, WHEN, WHAT, WHERE — are present (use n.d. if there's truly no date).

How to answer exam questions

Read the **command word** first — it sets how much to write. *State/Identify* wants a word or phrase; *Describe* wants features; *Explain* wants reasons and links; *Justify/Evaluate* wants a judgement backed by evidence. Always pull in the **scenario detail** rather than answering in the abstract. The examples below contrast a weak response with a strong one for the same question.

Q1. Distinguish

Between primary and secondary data, giving one example of each in a data-analysis project.

✗ A weak answer

Primary is your own data and secondary is other people's data. Like a survey or the internet. The weak answer is vague and its examples aren't tied to definitions. The strong answer defines by who collected the data and gives matched, project-relevant examples.

✓ A strong answer

Primary data is original data the analyst collects first-hand for their specific purpose — for example, a survey the student runs on canteen preferences. Secondary data is data already collected and published by someone else and then reused — for example, ABS population figures downloaded from a data repository.

How the marks are awarded

- 1 mark: a correct definition that contrasts first-hand collection (primary) with reused/published data (secondary).
- 1 mark: a valid, distinct example of each that fits a data-analysis context.
- No mark for examples that don't match the definition (e.g. calling 'the internet' secondary without specifics).

Q2. Explain

A student downloads a dataset from a government repository for their project. Explain why they must reference it, and identify two components their APA reference must include.

✗ A weak answer

So they don't get caught copying. They need to put the website and the name. 'So they don't get caught' implies the rule is about punishment, not ethics — weak. Naming author and year (or title/source) as components earns the structural marks.

✓ A strong answer

They must reference it to acknowledge the intellectual property of the organisation that created the data and to avoid plagiarism, since it is secondary data they did not collect. An APA reference must include the author/organisation and the year (and the dataset title and source), allowing the assessor to verify the data.

How the marks are awarded

- 1 mark: a real purpose — acknowledging IP / avoiding plagiarism / enabling verification.
- 1 mark each (max 2): two correct components from author-organisation, year (date), title, [Data set] label, publisher/URL (source).
- Cap at 2 marks if no purpose is given.

Q3. Explain

Two reasons referencing is important in a data-analysis project, and relate referencing to the ethical use of data.

✗ A weak answer

Referencing is important so your work looks professional and you get better marks. It is ethical because copying is bad. The weak answer gives non-purposes and an unexplained ethics claim. The strong answer gives two developed reasons and ties referencing to named ethical principles (transparency, ownership).

✓ A strong answer

First, referencing acknowledges the intellectual property of those who created the data, giving fair credit. Second, it lets readers verify sources by tracing each claim to its origin, which supports trustworthy findings. Ethically, referencing enacts transparency and respects ownership and control of data — the analyst is open about where information came from rather than presenting others' work as their own.

How the marks are awarded

- 1 mark each (max 2) for two distinct, valid reasons (IP acknowledgement, avoiding plagiarism, verification, credibility).
- 1 mark for a clear ethical link (transparency / ownership / respect for creators).
- 1 mark for explanation quality — reasons developed, not just listed.
- 'Looks professional' / 'better marks' alone earns nothing.

Q4. Identify

The reference below contains three errors. Identify and correct them. "Chen L 2023. Screen time and adolescent sleep. journal of youth studies."

✗ A weak answer

It's wrong because it has no brackets and no full stops. Fix the spelling. The weak answer is non-specific ('fix the spelling'). The strong answer names each error and supplies the corrected form — exactly what 'identify and correct' demands.

✓ A strong answer

Error 1: the year is not in parentheses — it should read (2023). Error 2: the author needs initials and punctuation — Chen, L. Error 3: the journal name should be Title Case and italicised — Journal of Youth Studies. Corrected: Chen, L. (2023). Screen time and adolescent sleep. Journal of Youth Studies (italicised).

How the marks are awarded

- 1 mark each (max 3) for identifying AND correcting: (a) year not in parentheses (2023); (b) author format Chen, L.; (c) journal not capitalised/italicised Journal of Youth Studies in italics.
- Identifying without correcting earns half credit only if the correction is implied.
- Volume/issue/pages absence may be noted but the three primary errors above are the target.